Certificate Credibility Insights

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May 2025

Background

- 11 in-depth interviews (IDIs) conducted between April 22-25, 2025 with hiring managers (n=6) and talent acquisition professionals (n=5)
- To explore the **perceptions of credibility of professional certificate programs** and go beyond surface-level credibility factors to uncover specific certificate attributes that drive trust, perceived value, and employee evaluation in terms of hiring, promotions, raises, and role expansion.
  Certificates Credibility Foundational Research Plan & DG (April 2025)

Findings

Role of Certificates in Career Growth Decision Making

1. Hiring Manager Perspective: Certificates are generally seen as **signals of potential,** not necessarily expertise. They have **limited impact on hiring decisions** unless candidates can clearly demonstrate **relevant, applied, *and* job-ready expertise** via the program.

   💡 How might we enable the certificate to demonstrate application of skills?

   > 💬 *"Hiring decisions is not just about the certificate or the training program, it's about can that person take what they learned and apply those skills"~Daniel, Hiring Manager (Technology)*
   > 💬 *"I don't know if [certificates] carry much weight at the moment. The ones I've taken, some are nice, but just because they were able to pass the test. I want to see how [they] took the training and then applied it. I'd expect to see results on [their] resume...like because I've taken this, I was able to grow sales by X amount or I was able to grow my career at this." ~David E, Hiring Manager (IT Business / Sales)*

2. Talent Acquisition Perspective: For recruiters, certificates have **limited influence in selection**. They are **less a filter** and **more a narrative enhancer** or a way for candidates, particularly for career switchers or junior talent, to **signal intent**, **direction**, and **readiness to grow**.

   💡 How might we **help learners in building this narrative or assets** to translate the certificate into **proof of practical application**?

   > 💬 *"Certificates [are] part of the bigger picture — can definitely be additive, nice to have— [they] **show continued learning"** ~Brian H, Tech Startup Recruiter*

   > 💬 *"[Certificates] can **add to the story** later on in debriefings with hiring managers. 'Well this candidate has certificates[...] I think [they] could be someone that **likes to grow, wants to continue to move upwards** in their career" ~ Gabriel T, Talent Acquisition (Finance, Marketing, Business)*

3. Promotions, Raises, and Role Expansion: A certificate alone **doesn't outweigh demonstrated performance when it comes to promotion and raise decisions**. Nevertheless, the pursuit of certificates is **respected as a sign of continuous growth** and **can contribute to role expansion**. Employee initiative and opportunity to apply skills is important.

💡 How might we help users to drive performance and initiative from day 1 of the certificate, as well as after course completion?

> 💬 *"Just because you have a piece of paper doesn't mean that you get a raise. How is it relevant to the team? How is it relevant to you? What is the value add?" ~David E, Hiring Manager (IT Business / Sales)*

Certificate Attributes

💡 A certificate earns credibility not by how it looks, but by **what it demands of the learner** and **how directly it equips them to deliver value in the workplace**.

💡 **Capstone projects** can be impactful if they demonstrate **real-world applicability** and **job relevance**. However, it's **not the mere existence of the capstone that matters**, it's **how well it presents evidence (proof)** of what the learner can actually do.

TOP Ranked Signals of Credibility
(shown in ranking order)

1. Applicability and Real-World Relevance**:** The most important indicator of credibility is whether the skills taught align directly with real job tasks and industry needs.

> 💬 *[Applicability makes a certificate credible because] like **if there's a capstone**...something attached to this to make [read] 'here's the cert that I got and this is, the product of that'" ~Daniel, Hiring Manager (Technology)*

> 💬 *"I like to see **how it's relevant for today**; if it [will] truly help [my employees] future state—how it's **applicable to their tasks now** and map it back to what the industry wants." ~ Reema, Hiring Manager, (Business / Business Consulting)*

2. Rigor and Assessment Validity: Credibility increases when a program includes **demanding** and **challenging** learning experiences. This means:
   a. **Meaningful course length** that signals depth, not a shortcut
   b. **Goes beyond testing recall** through tests and quizzes and leans more into project-based work that **mirrors on-the-job challenges**
   c. Projects that put **skills into action**
   d. **Opportunities to collaborate** and **receive feedback** (i.e., mimic working in team environment, scenario-based learning)

💡 How might we help learners communicate the skills they put into action?

💡 How might we demonstrate that our courses ensure learners put skills taught into action and that gaining a certificate is not just passing a test?

💬 *"[A degree program is more credible because] [students are] exposed longer; had more classes and opportunities to develop skills than [say a] 12 week bootcamp" ~ Ana, Hiring Manager (UX Design)*

💬 *"I [need to] know that they are not able to [achieve] the certificate without knowing their stuff, I view those as more credible. Like you [couldn't] fluff your way through that, you couldn't make up the answers" ~Daniel, Hiring Manager (Technology)*

3. Issuer Credibility and Brand Association: While not ranked as highly as applicability / relevance and rigor, certificates from well-known institutions or platforms can still **signal quality** and **authenticity**.

    a. **Learners also place emphasis on issuer credibility** and brand association. Similar to hiring teams, learners believe it signals a guarantee of the program's **quality and trust among employers**. (Source)

    💬 *"It has to be from a definitive organization, not just a random one. Platforms are like all over the place. So definitely it puts a kind of a stamp that this person got a certificate from a recognized brand." ~Ankita S, Hiring Manager (Technology - IT)*

BOTTOM Ranked Signals of Credibility

(shown in ranking order **starting with the lowest ranking**)

1. Presentation and professional integrations (Lowest rank): No weight given by both hiring managers and recruiters to this (almost all ranked this at the bottom of the list). They simply care more about what was learned and applied than how the certificate looks.

    💡 **Less resources** should be devoted **to visual polish** of the certificate and **more on helping learners showcase** the **applied skills and rigor of the program**.

    💬 *"Okay, so it looks good...**doesn't necessarily mean that it is credible**" ~ Daniel M, Hiring Manager (Technology)*

    💬 *"A smart enough person can doctor anything. Just because you make it look nice on paper, **I don't care, anybody can do that**" ~David Y, Hiring Manager (Technology)*

    💬 *"Having a nice little seal on it for LinkedIn **doesn't really matter**. [It's] is about why did they take it, what did they gain out of it, what was the process like to receive it and go through it" ~Gabriel, Recruiter (Finance, Marketing, Business)*

    💬 *"The market is so flooded with certificates, **anyone can make a certificate that looks great**. I don't think that's what hiring managers really care about." ~Justin, Senior Tech Recruiter*

2. Peer and employer recognition: Hiring managers and recruiters appear skeptical of **testimonials or marketing claims**, as a result this **carries less weight** unless they come from first-hand experience or recognized professionals (e.g., trusted professional with direct experience hiring, colleague who completed the certificate

and demonstrates expertise as a result, or respected hiring manager the industry advocates for it)

a. Learner context: However, **learners put greater emphasis on peer and industry-backed recognition than hiring managers** and appear more trusting of reviews. For them, these reviews and testimonials serve as a proven track record that reassures them that their investment will pay off. (Source)
    i. Examples of peers (Learners): Looking / reaching out to industry-professionals on Linkedin who have the certificate, manager/boss recommendation
    ii. Examples of industry-backed (Learners): large brands relevant to their industry (Google, Amazon, Microsoft, Cisco) and high-level executives in the industry or at large companies, top universities.

3. Integration with the hiring ecosystem: Participants viewed this similar to peer and employer recognition, and still feel that formal recognition by their company or internal hiring manager can enhance perceived value. It is still considered a **nice-to-have rather than a primary signal of credibility**. Hiring managers and talent acquisition professionals feel they still prioritize real-world relevance, skill applicability, and program rigor over institutional endorsements alone.

TABLE: Most / Least Important Signals of Cert Credibility (Top & Bottom 3 Rankings)

		Overall		Hiring Managers		Recruiters	
#	Item	*Most Important*	*Least Important*	*Most Important*	*Least Important*	*Most Important*	*Least Important*
1	Rigor and Assessment Validity	8	2	4	1	4	1
2	Issuer Credibility and Brand Association	5	2	2	2	3	0
3	Verification and Authenticity	3	5	2	2	1	3
4	Applicability and Real-World Relevance	10	1	6	0	4	1
5	Outcome-Based	2	3	2	2	0	1
6	Presentation and Professional Integration	0	10	0	5	0	5
7	Peer and Employer Recognition	3	5	2	3	1	2
8	Integration with Hiring Ecosystems	2	5	0	3	2	2

***Green** = performed well (many rated them in their top three most important signals of credibility).*
Yellow = did not perform well (many rated them in their bottom three least important signals of credibility).

Descriptions Shown to Participants

1. Rigor and Assessment Validity: The certificate demonstrates real, high-level skills through rigorous assessments/tests and final capstone projects— not just attendance or participation.
2. Issuer Credibility and Brand Association: The certificate is issued by a respected university, company, or recognized expert.

3. Verification and Authenticity: The certificate achievement can be independently confirmed — such as through a digital badge, blockchain verification, or public registry to ensure it's real.
4. Applicability and Real-World Relevance: The skills taught align directly with real-world job tasks, industry demands, and current hiring needs — not just theoretical knowledge.
5. Outcome-Based: There is proof that earning the certificate leads to meaningful career benefits, such as promotions, job offers, salary increases, or expanded roles.
6. Presentation and Professional Integration: The certificate looks polished, official, and professionally designed to display on a resume, LinkedIn, or portfolio.
7. Peer and Employer Recognition: The certificate is praised, valued, or recommended by industry peers, alumni, or employers — not just by the issuing organization.
8. Integration with Hiring Ecosystems: The certificate is formally recognized, preferred, or required by respected companies, hiring managers, or promotion committees.

General Drivers of Career Growth Decisions: Hiring, Promotion, Raises, and Role Expansion

💡 How can we better position our certificate program to reflect the real signals of growth and readiness that hiring managers and recruiters trust, like applied expertise, initiative, and industry relevance?

1. **Candidate Selection (Talent Acquisition Perspective)**
   Talent acquisition professionals prioritize stable career paths and industry-specific expertise, which signal lasting value. While academic qualifications still matter for select roles, **practical experience is a better predictor of long-term success than obtaining a degree or certificate alone**.

2. **Hiring Decisions (Hiring Manager Perspective)**
   When it comes to hiring decisions, hiring managers are placing greater emphasis on those who **show applied expertise**, **independent drive**, and a **culture fit**.

3. **Promotions, Raises, and Role Expansion**
   Promotions, raises, and role expansion are **less about static qualifications and more about proactive momentum**. Employees who take initiative to actively grow themselves and their teams are those most recognized and advanced
   Themes: momentum (performance + initiative), team impact not just individual

Appendix

Raw Data of Rankings

Rank1=Most Important for Cert Credibility, Rank8=Least Important for Cert Credibility

Role	Name	Rank1	Rank2	Rank3	Rank4	Rank5	Rank6	Rank7	Rank8
HM	Daniel M	4	1	5	8	7	2	6	3
HM	Ankita S	2	3	4	1	5	8	7	6
HM	David Y	4	1	3	2	5	7	8	6
HM	Reema B	4	5	7	8	3	1	2	6
HM	David E	4	1	7	8	2	3	5	6
HM	Ana G	4	2	1	3	6	5	7	8
TA	Heidi M	1	2	4	8	3	5	6	7
TA	Brian H	4	7	8	2	5	3	1	6
TA	Gabriel T	8	1	2	5	7	4	3	6
TA	Justin M	1	4	3	2	5	8	7	6
TA	Vicki G	1	4	2	7	5	8	3	6

HM=Hiring Manager, TA=Talent Acquisition Professionals

TLDR Capstone Artifacts

TLDR - Capstone artifacts can bridge that gap between learning and employability and from passive proof of completion into evidence of capability.

1. Hiring teams don't hire certificates. They hire proof that someone can apply skills in real contexts and deliver value.

2. What gives a certificate credibility is *how* they applied it, what impact it had, and how clearly that value is communicated.

3. To be credible, a capstone artifact **must clearly show how the learner applied key skills to create impact in a realistic context**. Think: results, relevance, and rigor. It should read less like a school project and more like evidence of job readiness.

   Based on research*, **artifacts should include** (in order of importance). Further details and suggestions below.

   1. Statements that demonstrate impact (e.g., like "By applying [skill] in [domain or problem space], I delivered [specific impact or outcome] in [real-world or simulated context].")

   2. Results-oriented skills descriptors (not just a skill list): Writing and editing long-form content optimized for SEO)

   3. Linkable projects or detailed work samples that showcase real-world or simulated deliverables that mirror professional outputs.

   4. Description of effort/rigor and evaluation required including course hours, topics covered, evaluation criteria, partner involvement (e.g., "Curriculum co-designed with..." or "Evaluated using standards set by...")

   5. Prominently featured dual-branded certificate of completion, as issuer name is a strong signal of rigor.

4. We need to **go a step further (beyond capstone)** to help learners *apply their skills in the real world*—via guidance, encouragement, and prompts.

   - **Building a narrative**: Provide guidance or templates for writing results-oriented LinkedIn posts or portfolio write-ups.

   - **Encourage learners** to apply their capstone to a real-world context (e.g., side project, internship, freelance, or team initiative at work).

   - Include prompts within the program to **reflect on where and how these skills can be used**, **and** ways learners could **act on those reflections**.

Sources:
Report: Certificate Credibility Insights (April 2025)
Certificates Pre-Paywall Maze test - April 2025
Certificate Focus Group Results, August 2024

Details: Examples of Shareable Artifacts

Pulled from qualitative research with hiring managers and learners.

1. **Statements that demonstrate impact** like "By applying [skill] in [domain or problem space], I delivered [specific impact or outcome] in [real-world or simulated context]."
    - *"Proof that they put them under real time business scenarios" ~ Hiring Manager*
    - *"I wanna see more that they used it and applied it" ~ Hiring Manager*
    - *"Because I've taken this, I was able to grow sales by X amount or I was able to grow my career at this." ~ Hiring Manager*
2. **Results-oriented skills descriptors** with clarity on how skills were used (not just listed). For example, designed multi-channel campaign strategy across email and social, wrote and edited long-form content optimized for SEO.
    - *"Saying I'm certified in [skill] is not enough. I want to see you created something using that skill" ~ Hiring Manager*
3. **Linkable capstone project (ideal) or descriptions** to showcase certificates goes beyond testing recall and includes hands-on training
    - *"Capstone attached to the certificate shows here's the cert that I got and this is a the product of that cert" ~ Hiring Manager*
    - *"Seeing the project or here's what I worked on, who I worked on it with and how. That's extremely helpful to me. 'cause I get to see their mindset" ~ Hiring Manager*

5. **Effort and evaluation methods used and required signal rigor and credibility.** Time becomes less of an issue if we can demonstrate opportunities to develop those skills.
    - *"They had more classes and more opportunities to develop those skills than a 12 week bootcamp person might have." ~ Hiring Manager*
    - *"Having some sort of evaluation and assessment that shows somebody actually evaluated and assessed the projects and the work" ~ Hiring Manager*
6. **Issuer and program** clarity (e.g., MasterClass + Partner, robust assessments)
    - Findings from research indicate the respected partners (e.g., Anthropic) of the program could elevate perceptions of the capstone rigor and trustworthiness. Source